regions share different political aspirations and the Pir Panjal population mainly comprises Gujjars and Bakerwals who, though Muslim, are ethnically different from Kashmiris. Their voting pattern is also different, which can tilt the power equation as south Kashmir (Anantnag) is a low voter turnout area. The poll percentage has not crossed 30 per cent in the past two elections here, a direct contrast to Poonch and Rajouri where the poll percentage crosses 70 per cent. "They have tied one person's nose with another's feet," says Awami National Conference vice-president Muzaffar Shah, alluding to Pir Panjal's merger with Anantnag seat. "This is the height of absurdity."

Historian and political commentator Siddiq Wahid notes that there was no transparency in the delimitation exercise as it was obviously meant to give an advantage to Jammu. Even so, if the elections are conducted today in a transparent manner, the BJP does not stand a chance, according to the former vice-chancellor of the Islamic University of Science & Technology. "Not just in J&K, even in Ladakh, their chances do not look too bright," he says.

Meanwhile, the People's Alliance for Gupkar Declaration (PAGD), an opposition grouping of political parties led by NC grandee Farooq Abdullah, is kickstarting a protest campaign next month in both Jammu and Kashmir. The PAGD's white paper, 'The Betrayal', listing the charges against the BJP from the past two-plus years, is also coming out as a book. "We oppose the delimitation but we will participate in the election to ensure the BJP doesn't get J&K on a platter," says a senior PAGD leader pleading anonymity. The coalition, comprising the NC, Peoples Democratic Party (PDP), JK People's Movement and CPI(M)—the People's Conference led by Sajjad Lone had exited the group by then—had swept the District Development Council election in 2020, emerging as the single largest party, winning 110 seats to the BJP's 75.

In Jammu, too, an opposition combine, the All Parties United Morcha (APUM), comprising major political parties and social organisations, has come together to launch an agitation against the new recommendations.

The BJP has enjoyed strong support in Hindu-dominated Jammu where it won 25 seats in the previous assembly election in 2014. It is expected that the increase in six seats here will give an edge to the saffron party, for five of them are Hindu-dominated. The uptake in recent opposition activity, though, could dent its chances.

Within the PAGD too, there is some disquiet. Murmurs about the NC's stand on the final delimitation report have raised questions. The NC was somewhat muted in its response, saying it was studying the impact of the report. People's Conference spokesperson Adnan Ashraf Mir questions the NC's silence and alleges that the cases against party leaders was behind it—Farooq, along with others, are being probed by the Enforcement Directorate for alleged irregularities in use of grants given to the J&K Cricket Association between 2002 and 2011. "What is there to study in detail? The macro report has been submitted and the big problem now is disempowerment and disenfranchisement of Kashmir by giving six seats to Jammu and only one to the Valley. They (NC) laid down the conditions for participation in the exercise...does this mean they have accepted it? Either they were lying or this is complete surrender," he says. Mir has a case—43.8 per cent of the population in Jammu will now vote in 47.8 per cent of the seats while the 56.2 per cent voters in Kashmir will vote in only 52.2 per cent of the seats.

Meanwhile, with the delimitation report in, speculation has again started that the long overdue assembly election may finally get a push. "The prime minister and home minister keep talking about elections after delimitation. But we don't know whether polls will be held," says the Valley's senior CPI(M) leader M.Y. Tarigami. "People want elections, but who listens to them? The Centre is more concerned about furthering its own agenda."

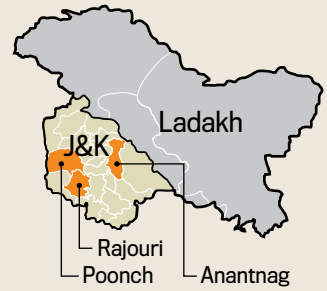
J&K has been without an elected government since the BJP pulled the plug on its alliance with the Mehbooba Mufti-led PDP in June 2018. Since then, the erstwhile state has been downgraded to two Union territories with the culmination being the scrapping of Article 370 (which gave J&K special status) in August 2019.

BJP national general secretary and J&K in-charge Tarun Chugh reiterates the party's stand that an assembly election will be held this year. The party claims to have made inroads into Muslim-majority Kashmir by building a base of 400,000-plus members and says it will field candidates in all the assembly constituencies in the Valley (it has yet to open an account here).

Government insiders, however, say they are yet to receive any signal about the polls. A senior official at the election commissioner's office says it's too early to talk about elections for a revision of electoral rolls itself will take almost five months to complete. ■

THE NEW ORDER

The Delimitation Commission's recommendations have not gone down well in the Valley



- Six new seats for Jammu (total 43 now), one for Kashmir (47) in new 90-member legislative assembly
- New seats in Jammu are in Kathua, Reasi, Doda, Rajouri, Kishtwar, Samba districts; Kupwara in Kashmir
- 16 reserved seats, 9 for STs), including three in Kashmir, 7 for SCs (all in Jammu)
- 28 assembly constituencies redrawn, 19 renamed
- One Lok Sabha constituency will consist of 18 assembly constituencies
- Rajouri, Poonch merged with Anantnag LS seat